CHAPTER 2

20 MENTZ AVENUE

'Take that cap off now. You're not worthy of wearing that cap.'

He was serious. I was shocked. All I had done was drop a catch off his bowling, but there was never going to be much of an argument. He was 22, and I was 11. So I did as I was told and removed my cap, my precious 'Jonty cap', the cap bought for me by my father when, on Friday, 17 November 1995, he took me to watch the second day of the first Test between South Africa and England at Centurion Park in Pretoria. For a young fast bowler named Shaun Pollock, it was his Test debut. For me, a boy in the crowd, it was my first ever experience of Test cricket.

The cap was my souvenir of a special occasion. It was green and had the name of my hero, Jonty Rhodes, in gold across the front; it instantly became my most prized possession.

'You don't deserve it,' repeated Gerrit Deist, the 22-year-old, a friend of my eldest brother Jan. As he spoke, he took the cap, threw it on the ground and trampled it into the dirt of our garden at 20 Mentz Avenue in Warmbaths.

I could feel the tears welling.

Don't cry, don't cry, I told myself, desperate not to look weak in front of Jan, 22, my middle brother Wessels, 17, and their friends, who had come to our house to play garden cricket, as they often did.

To be clear, I was working rather than truly participating and I was